

3.5%

SHARE OF OVERWEIGHT CHILDREN IN UNDER-FIVE AGE GROUP IN INDIA, UP FROM 1.5% IN 2005-06

14%

OBESITY AND OVERWEIGHT PREVALENCE AMONG KIDS IN PRIVATE SCHOOLS, TWICE THE 7.2% IN GOVT SCHOOLS

sidered overweight when their weight-for-height/length score is more than two steps (+2 standard deviation, or SD) above the healthy median for their age group and gender, and obese when it's three steps (+3 SD) higher. That's why tracking a child's growth with a paediatrician is more reliable than judging by appearance or family perception.

Recent data shows why early vigilance matters. A 2024 Cambridge University Press study based on the National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS-5) found the proportion of overweight children under five has doubled—from 1.9 per cent in earlier rounds to around 4 per cent—in many states. The UNICEF–WHO–World Bank Joint Child Malnutrition Estimates (2025) place it at 3.5 per cent nationally, up from 1.5 per cent two decades ago. The risk deepens with age and affluence. A 2024 review in the *Indian Journal of Endocrinology and Metabolism*, analysing 21 studies conducted between 2007 and 2022 and involving nearly 71,500 school-going children aged 5–18, found that combined overweight and obesity rates exceeded 14 per cent in private schools—roughly twice the 7.2 per cent recorded in government schools. Once dismissed as a western affliction, childhood obesity is now among India's fastest rising health threats.

Dr Ganesh Jevalikar, director of Paediatric Endocrinology at Max Super Speciality Hospital, Saket, calls the trend "extremely concerning". For, 'adiposity rebound'—the point at which body fat starts to rise again—used to earlier occur around the age of six or seven years. "Now, it's shifting downwards," says Dr Jevalikar. "Obesity at an early age is associated with a higher risk of adulthood obesity and metabolic syndrome. The rise in the incidence of non-communicable diseases and their occurrence at younger ages is also a direct result of childhood obesity."

WHERE IT ALL BEGINS

In a country that once measured child health by calories gained, the pendulum has swung the other way: calories now need restraint. Public health experts describe this as a clear epidemiological transition, where malnutrition and obesity now coexist—sometimes within the same family.

So, what's driving this silent surge? The roots often form long before a child takes their first steps—or even their first breath. Mothers who gain excessive weight during pregnancy or develop gestational diabetes expose the foetus to elevated glucose and insulin levels, altering metabolic set-points for life. "Maternal diets high in refined carbohydrates, sugary drinks and processed foods are increasingly associated with infants born with higher birth weights and greater adiposity (body fat)," says Dr Anita Gupta, a Delhi-based gynaecologist. "Such infants tend to gain weight rapidly in early life, suggesting a nutritional influence even before birth." And this is being observed with growing frequency in India, she notes.



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DR ANITA GUPTA, *Delhi-based gynaecologist*